alone, on an 80-hectare farm. It was a big farm with forty-four cows, eight horses, and twenty-five to thirty pigs.' For the cereal harvest, Polish reapers strained every muscle harvesting rye, wheat, barley and oats with the scythe. 'I worked with the scythe, too,' he radiantly declared.

It was all still manual work. I received no pay there. For me, what was important was that I performed my work with pleasure and at the same time obtained shelter and provisions. And the farmer provided clothes as well. The farmer had hoped that I might marry one of his daughters, but I was still too young and was not motivated in that direction.

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After two years, he was back in Wiebelskirchen hatching grandiose plans to work on the railways – alas, to no avail. 'Every lad has some kind of dream,' he proclaimed. 'That was my dream.' There was some consolation, however. Almost at once, he found himself mastering the basics of roofing with his uncle, Ludwig Weidenhof, a lanky ex-army gunner. The work was hard, but Honecker thrived on it. He acquired on-the-job experience stripping tiles and slating before starting an apprenticeship with Wiebelskirchen master roofer Franz Müller. 'I fell in love with my job because it involved a certain freedom of movement. You got around, saw the world from above. It was a job not without its dangers and always demanded attentiveness, prudence, precision, and skill.'9

Away from work, Honecker committed himself to the KJVD and attended the 1929 national youth rally and joined the Communist Party, which then recorded 120,000 members in industrial areas like Hamburg, Berlin, Leipzig, the upper Silesian coal-mining areas and northern shipyards. As this was happening, over in New York, Americans were reeling from a devastating stock market crash that led to the most destructive depression in modern history. 'I joined the party in 1929 at a time of heightened social